Shmini 5783

פרשת שמיני discusses the glorious day that the משכן was dedicated and the כהנים began to do the עבודה. At the beginning of the פרשה, the שכינה was שורה, and all the people saw it. This is followed by the tragedy of נדב and אביהוא. In their enthusiasm and קדושה to serve Hashem, they performed an עבודה that was uncalled for. Since it was not a צווי from Hashem, they paid the ultimate price and were burnt up. Immediately after that, the תורה says (10:3) וַיִּדֹּם אַהֲרֹן - אהרן accepted Hashem's judgment in silence. In the great זכות of וַיִּדֹּם אַהֲרֹן, he was זוכה to receive the next פרשה in the תורה, the פרשה of שתויי יין. The פסוק states: וַיְדַבֵּר ה׳ אֶל אַהֲרֹן לֵאמֹר, rather than the usual wording of וַיְדַבֵּר ה׳ אֶל מֹשֶׁה לֵאמֹר. Immediately following this, משה רבינו commanded them to continue the עבודה. However, when he discovered that not all of the קרבנות had been eaten, the פסוק states (10:16): וְאֵת שְׂעִיר הַחַטָּאת דָּרֹשׁ דָּרַשׁ מֹשֶׁה וְהִנֵּה שָׂרֻף וַיִּקְצֹף עַל אֶלְעָזָר וְעַל אִיתָמָר בְּנֵי אַהֲרֹן הַנּוֹתָרִם לֵאמֹר - Moshe became angry at אלעזר and איתמר that the קרבן חטאת had been burnt, accusing them of neglecting their responsibility. אהרן הכהן defended them, explaining that they were אוננים, and as רש"י brings down, an אונן is אסור to do the עבודה. משה immediately acknowledged his mistake and admitted, "You're right, I forgot." He was not embarrassed to admit he was wrong.

Now let's focus on the first half of the פסוק, וְאֵת שְׂעִיר הַחַטָּאת דָּרֹשׁ דָּרַשׁ מֹשֶׁה. Everyone knows that this phrase is unique in the חומש. In my חומש, it notes: דרש מכאן, ודרש מכאן - חצי התורה בתיבות. This means that דָּרֹשׁ דָּרַשׁ marks the exact midpoint of the תורה in terms of words. The ספר דגל מחנה אפרים brings a גיוועלדיק דבר תורה on this phrase. He quotes the מסורה that states כאן חצי התורה, and he explains as follows. תורה שבכתב and תורה שבעל פה are one entity. Together, they form a complete and unified תורה. Through תורה שבעל פה, we are able to fathom, grasp, and understand the deep and hidden secrets within תורה שבכתב. Without תורה שבעל פה, the written Torah cannot be fully understood - it is only half of a ספר. Everything is hidden within it, and only through the י"ג מידות and the רוח הקודש of our חכמים were these secrets unlocked, allowing us to comprehend the תורה הקדושה. Therefore, the דגל מחנה אפרים uses a very strong lashon: מי שכופר בקל וחומר או דרוש אחד מן החכמים כופר בתורת משה - Not only is it כפירה to deny a פסוק or a הלכה, but even if a person does not accept the י"ג מידות as תורה שבעל פה, he is considered a כופר.

This is what the פסוק is teaching us: דָּרֹשׁ דָּרַשׁ מֹשֶׁה - this is half of the תורה, to teach us that תורה שבעל פה is the other half of the תורה שבכתב. If a person only has תורה שבכתב, he only has half of the תורה. The דרשות of תורה שבעל פה complete the תורה, making it a single, unified entity. It is therefore perfectly fitting that חצי התורה falls exactly on these words. This is the secret hidden within this דרשה - דָּרֹשׁ דָּרַשׁ מֹשֶׁה - to teach us that only when we have the תורה בשלמותה can we truly understand and fulfill all of Hashem's ציוויים.

https://youtu.be/IRqK6I4BZgc